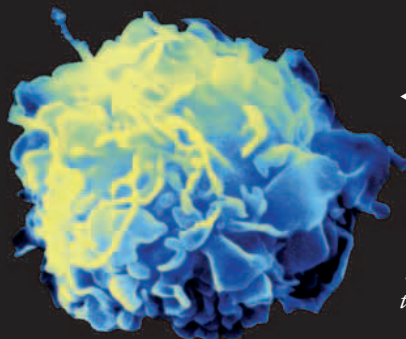


White blood cells

The human body contains about 50 billion white blood cells. These are the body's defenders—they wander through blood and other body fluids seeking out germs such as bacteria and viruses and killing them. Some also seek and destroy the faulty body cells that cause cancer.

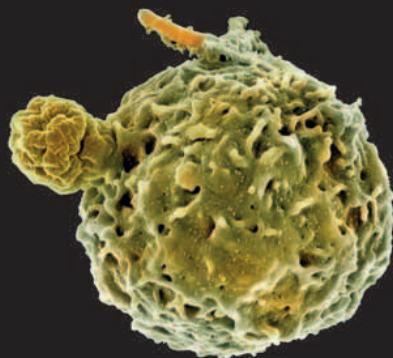
DEFENSE FORCE

There are several different types of white blood cells, each suited to attacking particular types of germs. Most are made in bone marrow, a jellylike tissue found in the hollow spaces inside bones. White blood cells live for only 3–4 days each. When you're sick, the number of white blood cells rises as your body fights the disease.



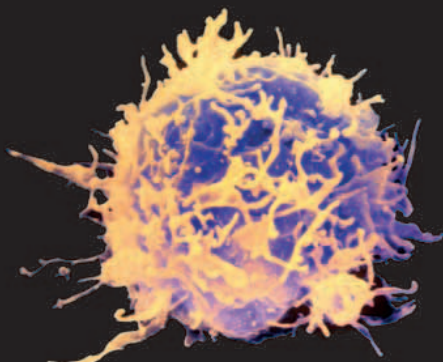
◀ BIG EATERS

Macrophage cells eat and kill germs such as bacteria. They also swallow up flecks of dirt and debris in injured tissue, helping to clean up wounds.



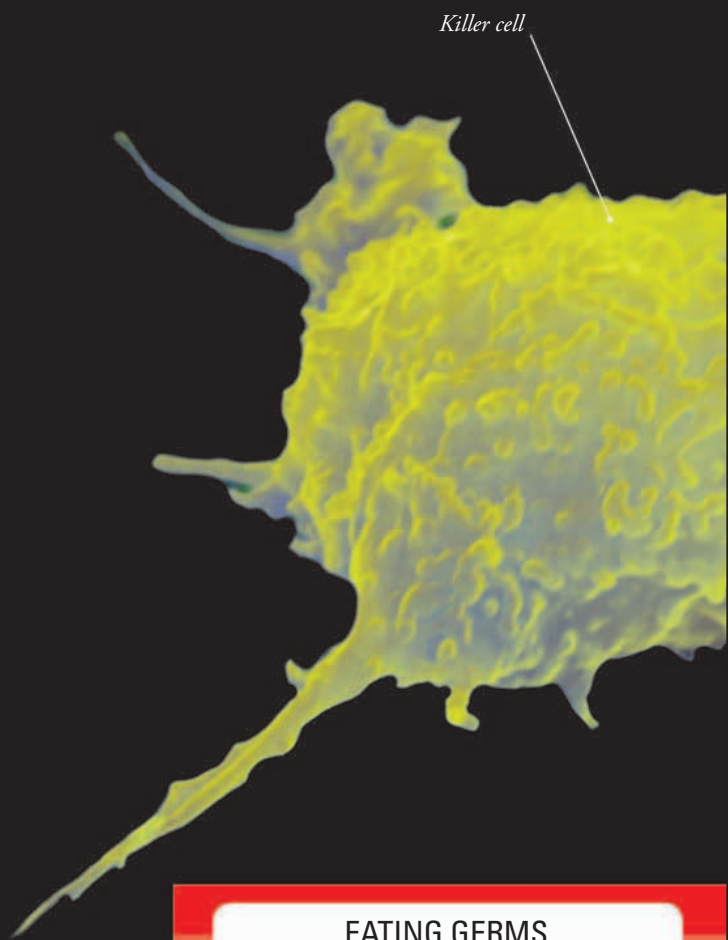
◀ FIRST DEFENSE

Neutrophils are the most common type of white blood cell. They are first on the scene to destroy invading germs when your skin is cut. They collect by the thousand in wounds, forming a yellowish substance called pus.



◀ SPECIALIZED KILLERS

Instead of attacking any invader, a lymphocyte learns to attack just one specific type of germ. Lymphocytes kill germs in various ways. Some stick to germs and flood them with poison. Others release chemicals called antibodies, which stick to germs and attract other types of white blood cells.



Killer cell

EATING GERMS

Macrophages and neutrophils destroy germs in the same way. Roaming through blood and other body fluids, they hunt invading microbes, particularly bacteria, by following their chemical trails. Once in contact with a bacterial cell, they confirm the target as "foreign" by examining the chemicals on its surface. Then the defender surrounds the enemy cell, which takes only a second, and digests it. This process of capture and destruction is called phagocytosis.